



SUSTAINABLE OLYMPIAD

Sustainable Olympiad 2026: Official Rulebook

Young minds. Real solutions. One planet. Global Finals: 28–30 October 2026, Lisbon (Portugal), Brazil and online.

1. Eligibility

The Olympiad is open to students aged 12 to 25 who are enrolled in a school, college or university during 2026.

- **Junior division:** students aged 12–14 on 1 August 2026.
- **Senior division:** students aged 15–18 on 1 August 2026.
- **University division:** undergraduate students aged 18–25.
- A team competes in the division of its oldest member.

2. Teams and mentors

Each team has 2 to 5 students and one supervising mentor aged 21 or over, normally a teacher or lecturer.

- Students may belong to only one team per edition.
- A mentor may supervise up to three teams.
- Mentors guide and support, but the work must be done by the students.
- Team members can be replaced until the Round 1 start date by contacting the organisers.

3. Registration

Registration is free and is completed online by the team captain before the registration deadline.

- Each team chooses one category when registering. The category can be changed until Round 1 starts.
- For students under 18, the mentor confirms that parental or guardian consent has been obtained.
- Schools may register more than one team.

4. Competition format

The Olympiad has three stages. Teams that do not advance still receive written feedback and a certificate of participation.

- **Round 1, Online Knowledge Challenge:** a 90-minute multiple-choice and short-answer quiz taken together as a team.
- **Round 2, Project Challenge:** ten days to build and test a solution to the category brief, with a report of up to 3,000 words and a three-minute video.
- **Global Finals:** a ten-minute presentation and a ten-minute question-and-answer session with the jury, in person or online.

5. Project submissions

Round 2 submissions are uploaded through the participant portal before 23:59 Brasília time on the deadline date.

- Reports are submitted as PDF and videos as MP4 or a public video link.
- Videos must include captions, and reports must use headings and alt text for images.
- All sources, data sets and tools, including AI tools, must be credited.
- Late submissions are accepted only in documented emergencies.

6. Judging

Projects are scored by an independent jury of scientists, educators, engineers and entrepreneurs. Each project is reviewed by at least three judges.

- Environmental impact: 30%
- Innovation: 25%
- Feasibility: 20%
- Scientific rigour: 15%
- Communication: 10%
- Judges declare any conflict of interest and do not score teams from their own institution.
- The jury's decisions are final.

7. Academic integrity

Teams must submit their own original work. Plagiarism, data fabrication or undisclosed outside help leads to disqualification.

- AI tools may be used for research and editing, provided their use is described in the report.
- Projects must not have won another international competition before.

8. Safety and ethics

Experiments must be carried out safely and under adult supervision where needed.

- No project may harm people, animals or ecosystems.
- Research with human participants requires informed consent and must protect their privacy.
- Mains electricity, hazardous chemicals and power tools may be used only under a mentor's supervision.

9. Code of conduct

The Olympiad is an inclusive community. Participants, mentors, judges and volunteers treat each other with respect.

- Harassment and discrimination of any kind are not tolerated.
- Concerns can be reported confidentially to the organisers at any time.

10. Accessibility and reasonable adjustments

We want everyone to be able to take part. Teams can request adjustments such as extra time, screen-reader-compatible quiz formats, sign language interpretation or step-free venue access.

- Request adjustments in the registration form or by contacting us at least two weeks before the relevant round.

11. Intellectual property and media

Teams keep full ownership of their ideas and projects.

- By entering, teams allow the organisers to share project summaries, photos and videos to promote the Olympiad, with credit.
- Teams may opt out of photography at the Finals.

12. Prizes

Gold, silver and bronze medals are awarded in each category and division. The Planet Award goes to the best project overall.

- Winning teams receive grants of up to €5,000 to develop their project further.
- All finalists receive certificates and mentoring from our partners.

Divisions

Division	Who can enter
Junior	Ages 12–14
Senior	Ages 15–18
University	Ages 18–25, undergraduate students

Judging criteria

Criterion	Weight	What judges look for
Environmental impact	30%	How much measurable good does the solution do for people and the planet?
Innovation	25%	Is the idea original, or does it apply an existing idea in a new way?
Feasibility	20%	Could the solution realistically be built, funded and scaled?
Scientific rigour	15%	Are the data, methods and conclusions sound?
Communication	10%	Is the project explained clearly to a non-specialist audience?

Competition categories

Renewable Energy

Teams investigate how communities can move away from fossil fuels. Projects may range from a solar-powered phone charging station to an energy audit that cuts a school's electricity bill.

2026 challenge brief: Reduce your school's energy use by at least 15% using low-cost, renewable or efficiency-based measures.

Waste Reduction & Circular Economy

Teams tackle the full life cycle of materials, from reducing single-use plastics to turning food waste into compost, biogas or new products.

2026 challenge brief: Cut the waste your school or neighbourhood sends to landfill and show measurable results over ten days.

Sustainable Design & Architecture

Teams apply eco-design principles to everyday objects, buildings or neighbourhoods, considering materials, energy, water and the wellbeing of the people who use them.

2026 challenge brief: Redesign one space or product in your community so that it uses fewer resources and serves people better.

Climate Solutions

Teams develop tools, campaigns or policy proposals that reduce emissions or help communities adapt to a changing climate, backed by sound data.

2026 challenge brief: Calculate a real carbon footprint in your community and propose a credible plan to reduce it.

Water & Oceans

New for 2026. Teams explore water scarcity, pollution and ocean health, building solutions that save, clean or protect water resources.

2026 challenge brief: Monitor a local water source for one month and design an intervention that improves its quality or reduces its use.

Biodiversity & Food Systems

Teams work on pollinator habitats, school gardens, urban farming or reducing the footprint of what we eat, combining field observation with practical action.

2026 challenge brief: Increase biodiversity on your school grounds and document the change with a species survey.

Key dates

Date	Milestone
3 August 2026	Registration opens
20 August 2026	Information webinar for teachers and mentors
15 September 2026	Early-bird deadline
9 October 2026	Registration deadline
10 October 2026	Round 1: Online Knowledge Challenge
13 October 2026	Round 1 results
14–23 October 2026	Round 2: Project Challenge
24 October 2026	Finalists announced
28–29 October 2026	Global Finals
30 October 2026	Awards Ceremony